

Ottonian art

Following Charlemagne's death, internal and external conflicts threatened the existence of the Holy Roman Empire. It was divided on several occasions, but consolidated again under various rulers. The most significant of these were three German emperors, each named Otto, who succeeded each other in what is now called the Ottonian period (c.951–1024). Under the reigns of Otto I, Otto II and Otto III, the Holy Roman Empire was revived, with a different geography and character. In many ways, the art produced was a continuation of Carolingian art.

Ottonian art was created in the Low Countries, northern Italy and eastern France. Coinciding with a period of Church reform, it fused ideas and traditions from Carolingian and Byzantine art, blended with northern European traditions. Illuminated manuscripts, metalwork, wall paintings and luxury objects for churches and treasuries expressed grandeur, with Christian iconography predominating. It was less sophisticated than Carolingian art, but also intense and vibrant.



Christ receiving the Magdeburg cathedral from Emperor Otto I, c.965 CE